ND SQUAD



SANJU SAMSON, 31

Wicketkeeper-batsman

For long, Sanju Samson was seen as the wicket-keeper-batter best equipped to fill the giant shoes of M.S. Dhoni in the Indian team. It was all there: the power to smash bowlers at will, classical poise and élan in stroke-making, the hunger to evolve. His Rajasthan Royals mate and former Australia captain Steve Smith knew he had the game "to make it big". But it didn't pan out as predicted; from being the heir apparent, he gradually saw the likes of K.L. Rahul and Rishabh Pant steal the spotlight. Opportunities would come, but he'd either be stranded on the bench or fail to capitalise on them. The IPL remained his favoured hunting ground. The T20 World Cup looked like yet another chance that would go flying past. Samson had already sat out the 2024 version. Two years later, now 31, his performance in the New Zealand series prior to the tournament had sowed doubt. His place was anything but guaranteed.

This time, fate had other plans for the man they fondly call 'Chetta' (brother). The opening pair of Abhishek Sharma-Ishan Kishan wasn't firing. As soon as Samson started opening, India's totals improved: 209, 256, 199 (batting second), 253 and 255. His strike rate of 199 wasn't slower than a pure slogger's, for he wasn't wasting balls: that famed back lift of his was whipping cream all night. Samson hit 24 sixes—most by anyone in a single T20 World Cup.

Thankfully, his form held till the end. His two knocks of 89 each in the semifinal and final guaranteed imposing Indian totals of 250 plus. From fighting for a spot in the XI to being Player of the Tournament, Samson's was a feelgood Cinderella story. Fans across India call it The Chetta Story. **—SS**

SURYAKUMAR YADAV, 35

Captain/ batsman

For Suryakumar Yadav, the call-up for the national team for T20s came late, at age 30. But he'd announce his arrival memorably—a six off Jofra Archer on the first ball he faced. From then on, with displays of batting prowess, he was hailed as "a 360-degree player". He was a top operator on the ground too—remember that catch on the boundary in the 2024 T20 World Cup final? A month later, he'd be appointed India's new T20 captain.

As Yadav became the chief executor of Gautam Gambhir's project to remodel India's white-ball cricket into a more attacking variant, his batting began to show cracks. In 2025, he scored 218 runs at an average of 13.62 across 21 T20 internationals. But, with the World Cup looming large in January 2026, Surya was back on track, scoring 242 runs against New Zealand in five innings at 80.66.

His maiden T20 World Cup as captain, in his own words, was not a "very smooth ride". SKY held fort in the opening tie against the USA, scoring 84 not out to ensure a decent team total. His performance in the knockout stages may have been modest, but when it came to taking crucial calls—like bringing Sanju Samson back into the squad or correcting the mistake of dropping Axar Patel against South Africa—Surya was spot on. When he says winning gold at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, where T20 cricket makes its debut, and winning three world titles in a row are the team's next targets, you take it as a serious statement of intent. **—SS**

SURYAKUMAR YADAV
MATCHES: 9
RUNS: 242
HS: 84*
S/R: 136.72

AFP

All stats are for the 2026 ICC T20 WC; HS=Highest Score; S/R=Strike Rate